Wilhelm Mannhardt — Wald- und Feldkulte (1875–1877)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Wilhelm Mannhardt, a Danzig librarian, chronically ill, who died at forty-nine after undertaking one of the largest pieces of fieldwork in the nineteenth-century study of folklore. In 1865 he sent out questionnaires across several languages — some 150,000 of them, by the figure reported in the sources for this research — to map the agrarian rituals of Europe as ordinary people still practised them. Out of the answers came *Wald- und Feldkulte*. The book then became the source from which Frazer built *The Golden Bough*: Frazer acknowledged the debt and cites Mannhardt throughout, and then the world read Frazer and forgot Mannhardt. This presentation is dedicated to restoring the collector's own name to the evidence he gathered, so that his book may be read in English as a book in its own right, and not only as a footnote to a more famous one.

The story

Wilhelm Mannhardt (1831–1880) was a Danzig librarian, chronically ill, who died at forty-nine — and who undertook one of the largest pieces of fieldwork in the nineteenth-century study of folklore. In 1865 he sent out some 150,000 questionnaires across several languages to map the agrarian rituals of Europe: the customs of field and forest, of sowing and harvest, as ordinary people still

practised them. That figure is given here exactly as it stands in the record for this research — as reported in the sources cited below; **UNCHECKED**.

Out of that labour came *Wald- und Feldkulte*, "Forest and Field Cults": the first volume, *Der Baumkultus der Germanen und ihrer Nachbarstämme*, "The Tree Cult of the Germanic Peoples and Their Neighbouring Tribes," in 1875, and the second, *Antike Wald- und Feldkulte*, "Ancient Forest and Field Cults," in 1877. The book then suffered a curious fate. It became the data-mine behind Frazer's *The Golden Bough*. Frazer acknowledged the debt — he cites Mannhardt throughout, by the abbreviations "Mannhardt, B.K." and "A.W.F." — and then the world read Frazer and forgot Mannhardt. A Valdosta State scholarly-texts page states his standing plainly: never translated, seldom read, mentioned only in passing as the *Golden Bough*'s data source. The librarian whom a famous book was built upon remains, in English, a footnote in the book he made possible.

The work and what survives

Both volumes survive. The Internet Archive copy, digitised by Google from the University of Wisconsin–Madison, holds both volumes, and the 1884 posthumous volume is noted in the same record family: Mannhardt's *Mythologische Forschungen* of 1884, published after his death and intended as the work's third volume. His manuscripts are at Berlin University Library. The work is in the public domain: the author died in 1880, and the imprints are 1875–77.

Its English fortunes

Uniquely in this survey, a scholarly source states the position in nearly the same words as this research's own finding — the Valdosta State page's "never translated, seldom read," quoted above. Frazer's citations run throughout *The Golden Bough* by abbreviation, which gives any English edition a ready-made cross-reference apparatus: readers could move between Mannhardt's evidence and the famous book that drew on it, passage by passage.

The bounded finding of this research, verified by review on 14 October 2026, is this: **No English translation found after research.**

What completing it would take

Completing the work would mean taking Volume 1 first — the tree cult of the Germanic peoples, about 668 pages — as a standalone volume, with Volume 2

and the posthumous *Mythologische Forschungen* to follow in their own time. The review standard set for it is a German reader together with a folklorist.

The restoration this work calls for is, at bottom, a matter of a name. Mannhardt asked the questions, in their tens of thousands, and gathered the answers from which a classic was built. An English *Wald- und Feldkulte* would let readers meet the evidence in the words of the man who collected it, and read Frazer's acknowledged source as a book in its own right at last.

Sources

- https://vtext.valdosta.edu/xmlui/browse?type=subject&value=Mannhardt%2C+Wilhelm%2C+1831-1880.+Wald-+und+Feldkulte (the "never translated, seldom read" assessment)
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Wilhelm_Mannhardt (life, the 1865 questionnaire survey, the two volumes, the posthumous vol. 3)
- http://www.readanybook.com/ebook/wald-und-feldkulte-197691 (the IA copy: Google/Wisconsin–Madison digitization, both volumes)
- https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Page:Frazer_(1890)*The_Golden_Bough*(IA_goldenboughstudy01fraz).djvu/94 (Frazer citing Mannhardt)